

Contextual Interpretation and Metaphorical Meanings in Kusaal Wellerisms

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Abstract

This paper investigates wellerisms, a distinctive subtype of proverbs, in Kusaal, a Mabia (Gur) language spoken in northeastern Ghana. Using a qualitative literary and ethnographic approach, the study analyses twenty wellerisms to examine the role of context in their interpretation and to explore the metaphorical meanings embedded in their structure. The findings show that the meanings of Kusaal wellerisms are highly dependent on the social and cultural contexts in which they are used. Their communicative value extends beyond literal interpretation, with meaning emerging through shared cultural knowledge and situational relevance. The analysis further reveals that Kusaal wellerisms rely heavily on personification, assigning human voices and experiences to animals, birds, and other creatures in order to comment indirectly on human behaviour, social relationships, and moral conduct. Through metaphorical mappings, experiences from the animal world are projected onto human life, generating conceptualisations such as “Life is a resource, knowing is seeing, success is a journey, responsibility is a burden, and opportunity is food.” These figurative constructions enable speakers to communicate advice, criticism, warnings, and moral lessons in culturally appropriate ways. The study also demonstrates that wellerisms serve important educational and social functions by promoting values such as prudence, resilience, self-reliance, patience, foresight, and communal responsibility, while discouraging hypocrisy, dishonesty, and recklessness. Although typically brief and memorable, they encapsulate complex layers of indigenous knowledge and cultural wisdom. The paper concludes that Kusaal wellerisms are important cultural resources that illuminate the moral philosophy, worldview, and metaphorical thought patterns of the Kusaa people.

Keywords: Kusaal, wellerisms, proverbs, metaphor, personification, pragmatics, folklore, indigenous knowledge, worldview.

Introduction

Proverbs constitute one of the most enduring forms of verbal art across human societies. They encapsulate collective wisdom, cultural values, moral principles, and practical knowledge accumulated over generations. As concise and memorable expressions, proverbs serve not only as rhetorical devices but also as repositories of indigenous knowledge through which communities interpret experience, regulate social behaviour, and transmit cultural norms. In African societies, proverbs occupy a particularly prominent place in everyday discourse, public speaking, conflict resolution, traditional adjudication, and informal education. Their significance lies not merely in their linguistic form but also in their ability to communicate complex ideas through figurative and culturally grounded expressions (Finnegan, 2012; Yankah, 1989).

Among the numerous proverb subgenres identified in paremiological studies is the wellerism. Named after the character Sam Weller in Charles Dickens’ *The Pickwick*

Papers, a wellerism typically consists of three components: a statement, a speaker, and a contextualising phrase that explains or humorously reinterprets the statement (Mieder, 2004). Wellerisms differ from ordinary proverbs in that they are often presented as direct quotations attributed to a specific speaker, whether human, animal, or supernatural. The attribution of speech to non-human entities creates opportunities for humour, irony, indirect criticism, and social commentary.

Although wellerisms have received considerable scholarly attention in European and North American traditions, they remain relatively underexplored in African oral literature. Yet African wellerisms display remarkable creativity and often draw on culturally salient animals, birds, insects, and other creatures to communicate social wisdom. Through personification, these creatures are transformed into speaking subjects whose experiences mirror those of human beings. Consequently, wellerisms function not only as entertainment but also as vehicles for moral instruction, social regulation, and cultural reflection.

Within African oral traditions, animals frequently serve as symbolic representations of human virtues, weaknesses, aspirations, and social relationships. Their attributed speech allows speakers to comment on sensitive issues indirectly while preserving social harmony. Such indirectness is particularly important in societies where overt criticism may be considered inappropriate or face-threatening. Wellerisms therefore occupy a unique position at the intersection of folklore, language, culture, and cognition.

Kusaal and the Kusaa Cultural Context

Kusaal is a Mbia (Gur) language spoken mainly by the Kusaasi people of northeastern Ghana, particularly in the Upper East Region, as well as in neighbouring parts of Burkina Faso and Togo. It belongs to the Western Oti-Volta subgroup of the Niger-Congo language family and comprises two major dialects: Agole (Nya'an) and Toende (Naden, 1988; Musah, 2018; Abubakari, 2018). Closely related to languages such as Dagbani, Mampruli, Fafari, and Mooré, Kusaal serves not only as a means of communication but also as a repository of cultural knowledge, identity, and traditional wisdom. Like many African societies, the Kusaas maintain a rich oral tradition that includes folktales, songs, riddles, myths, praise poetry, and proverbs. These oral forms play a central role in preserving collective memory and transmitting social values across generations. Proverbs in particular, occupy an important place in everyday life, featuring prominently in family discussions, marriage negotiations, dispute settlement, chieftaincy proceedings, and other social interactions. They provide culturally accepted ways of advising, warning, persuading, praising, and criticising without direct confrontation.

Kusaal Wellerisms

Among the various forms of Kusaal proverbial discourse are wellerisms, a distinctive proverb type in which animals, birds, insects, and other creatures are portrayed as speaking characters. A notable feature of these expressions is the use of the personifying prefix A-, which assigns human-like agency and voice to non-human beings. Through this linguistic device, animals become symbolic representatives of human experience, commenting on issues such as survival, prudence, responsibility, self-reliance, social

relationships, and communal life. Their messages are often humorous, metaphorical, and morally instructive, enabling speakers to communicate sensitive truths indirectly while maintaining social harmony.

Despite their widespread use, Kusaal wellerisms remain largely understudied. Existing research on Kusaal has focused mainly on areas such as phonology, morphology, syntax, naming practices, and euphemism, with limited attention given to proverbial genres. More specifically, little scholarly work has examined wellerisms as a distinct form of proverb within Kusaal or the wider Maba linguistic tradition. As a result, their linguistic structure, cultural significance, and cognitive foundations remain insufficiently documented. This is particularly important because wellerisms provide valuable insights into indigenous ways of thinking and meaning-making. Their interpretation often depends heavily on context, while their figurative meanings emerge through personification and metaphor, whereby animal experiences are mapped onto human experiences. Through these mappings, wellerisms express culturally grounded understandings of caution, success, responsibility, resilience, and social conduct. Against this background, the present study examines twenty Kusaal wellerisms to explore their linguistic, cultural, and cognitive significance. It investigates the role of context in their interpretation, analyses the metaphorical meanings and conceptual mappings they encode, examines how personification contributes to meaning construction, and identifies the cultural values and social philosophies they embody. In doing so, the paper contributes to scholarship on African oral literature, proverb studies, cognitive linguistics, and the documentation of Kusaal.

Wellerisms as a Distinct Proverb Genre

Wellerisms are a special type of proverb in which a statement is attributed to a specific speaker and often accompanied by a remark that clarifies or contextualises the utterance. Unlike ordinary proverbs that express wisdom directly, wellerisms present wisdom through a miniature narrative involving a speaker and a quoted statement. The term *wellerism* originates from the character Sam Weller in Charles Dickens' *The Pickwick Papers*, whose witty sayings popularised this form in English folklore (Mieder, 2004).

Scholars have shown that wellerisms occupy a unique place within proverbial discourse because they combine dialogue, humour, narrative, and social commentary. Their effectiveness often depends on the identity of the speaker, whose words gain meaning through the contrast between who is speaking and what is being said (Abrahams, 1968). By attributing speech to animals, objects, or stereotypical characters, wellerisms allow speakers to communicate criticism, advice, and observations indirectly, thereby avoiding direct confrontation (Dundes, 1975). They frequently employ humour, irony, exaggeration, and metaphor to communicate moral lessons and social values (Mieder, 2004).

The Kusaal wellerisms investigated in this study share these general features but also display distinctive local characteristics. Most notably, they rely heavily on personified animals as speakers. Through the use of the prefix *A-*, animals are transformed into social actors capable of commenting on human experiences. This practice situates Kusaal wellerisms within the broader wellerism tradition while reflecting indigenous modes of reasoning and cultural expression.

African Proverb Scholarship

Proverbs are among the most valued forms of oral literature in Africa and play important roles in communication, education, conflict resolution, and the transmission of cultural knowledge. They serve as repositories of collective wisdom through which communities preserve values, historical experiences, and worldviews (Finnegan, 2012). A central contribution to African proverb studies is Yankah's (1989) notion of *proverb praxis*, which emphasises that proverb meaning cannot be separated from the context in which it is used. According to this view, interpretation emerges through the interaction of speaker, audience, and situation rather than from the proverb alone. This insight is particularly relevant to Kusaal wellerisms, whose meanings are often shaped by the circumstances of their use.

Other scholars have similarly highlighted the cultural and moral significance of African proverbs. Asare (1997) notes that proverbs preserve cultural memory and provide socially acceptable ways of addressing delicate issues, while Opoku (1997) argues that they encapsulate indigenous philosophies concerning morality, leadership, and social relations. Studies of Ghanaian languages have also drawn attention to the artistic qualities of proverbs. For example, Ababila (2010) demonstrates that Gurene proverbs employ literary devices such as metaphor, symbolism, imagery, and personification to enhance their communicative power. Likewise, Amegashie and Asilevi (2010) show that Ewe wellerisms use humour and indirectness to communicate sensitive messages while maintaining social harmony. Together, these studies underscore the importance of proverbs and wellerisms as cultural resources through which African societies transmit wisdom, regulate behaviour, and preserve indigenous knowledge. The present study contributes to this growing body of scholarship by focusing on the relatively understudied area of Kusaal wellerisms.

Context and Proverb Interpretation

A widely accepted principle in proverb scholarship is that proverbial meaning is fundamentally context-dependent. Proverbs do not possess fixed meanings that can be fully understood in isolation; rather, their interpretation emerges from the interaction between text, culture, speaker intention, and situational context. Yankah's (1989) concept of *proverb praxis* highlights that proverbs acquire meaning through actual use. A single proverb may be employed in different situations and convey different implications while retaining a common core meaning. Similar views are found in linguistic anthropology and pragmatics, where scholars such as Hymes (1974), Bauman (1986), and Duranti (1997) emphasise the importance of social context and performance in shaping meaning.

This contextual perspective is especially relevant to African oral traditions, where proverbs often communicate indirectly and depend on shared cultural knowledge for interpretation. Accordingly, this study approaches Kusaal wellerisms as context-sensitive expressions whose meanings can only be fully understood within the communicative situations in which they occur.

Conceptual Metaphor Theory

The study is guided primarily by *Conceptual Metaphor Theory* (CMT), developed by Lakoff and Johnson (1980). CMT views metaphor not merely as a stylistic feature of language but as a fundamental mechanism through which people understand and organise experience. According to the theory, abstract concepts are often understood through more concrete and familiar experiences. This process involves systematic mappings between a source domain and a target domain. Familiar examples include metaphors such as “**Life is a journey and argument is war**”, where concrete experiences provide the framework for understanding abstract ideas.

A key assumption of CMT is that human cognition is grounded in embodied experience. Everyday interactions with the physical world, such as movement, vision, eating, and balance, shape the conceptual structures people use to interpret more abstract aspects of life. This framework is particularly useful for analysing Kusaal wellerisms because many of them draw on animal behaviour as a source domain for understanding human experiences such as responsibility, success, survival, morality, and social relations.

Personification as a Cognitive Device

Closely linked to metaphor is personification, which Lakoff and Johnson (1980) describe as a form of ontological metaphor whereby non-human entities are understood in human terms. Through personification, animals, objects, and natural phenomena are endowed with human qualities such as speech, intention, reasoning, and emotion. Kövecses (2010) argues that personification makes complex experiences more accessible by allowing people to interpret them through familiar human behaviour. Similarly, Gibbs (1994) maintains that personification reflects underlying cognitive processes rather than simply serving as a stylistic device. By attributing human agency to non-human entities, speakers create imaginative frameworks that facilitate understanding and communication.

In African oral traditions, animals frequently function as symbolic representations of human behaviour. Through personification, they become social actors capable of expressing wisdom, criticism, humour, and moral judgement. The Kusaal wellerisms examined in this study provide clear examples of this phenomenon. The prefix *A-* transforms animals such as dogs, monkeys, hyenas, rats, vultures, and birds into speaking characters whose experiences mirror those of humans. This personification strategy not only enriches the narrative quality of the wellerisms but also facilitates the metaphorical transfer of cultural knowledge and moral insight.

Methodology

This study employs a qualitative research approach to examine the contextual, metaphorical, and cultural meanings of Kusaal wellerisms. Data were collected through elicitation and semi-structured consultations with 12 native Kusaal speakers (8 males and 4 females) drawn from 5 communities in the Bawku West District of Ghana: Apoudaboog, Goore, Asapalig, Narog, and Widnaba. Participants were selected for their proficiency in Kusaal and knowledge of traditional oral forms, particularly proverbs and wellerisms. The participants provided wellerisms, explained their literal meanings, described the

situations in which they are used, and discussed their cultural significance. Their insights were essential because the meanings of wellerisms often depend on shared cultural knowledge and contextual interpretation rather than on literal wording alone.

The study is based on a corpus of twenty wellerisms covering themes such as survival, prudence, self-reliance, honesty, sexuality, perseverance, responsibility, and communal relations. A notable feature of these expressions is the use of the personifying prefix “A-”, which assigns human characteristics to animals, birds, and insects, allowing them to comment symbolically on human behaviour and social life.

Data analysis combined literary, cognitive, and descriptive approaches. Literary analysis focused on stylistic devices such as personification, symbolism, humour, irony, and imagery. Cognitive metaphor analysis, informed by Conceptual Metaphor Theory, examined how experiences from the animal world are mapped onto human experiences. Descriptive analysis was used to explain the meanings, contexts, and cultural implications of each wellerism. Although the corpus is relatively small and some interpretations rely on speakers’ recollections, the study provides one of the first systematic analyses of Kusaal wellerisms and contributes to the documentation of Kusaal oral literature, indigenous knowledge, and metaphorical thought.

Structural Characteristics of Kusaal Wellerisms

Before examining the thematic, pragmatic, and metaphorical dimensions of Kusaal wellerisms, it is necessary to consider their formal structure. The significance of wellerisms lies not only in the messages they convey but also in the linguistic mechanisms through which those messages are constructed. Like wellerisms found in other linguistic traditions, Kusaal wellerisms exhibit relatively stable structural patterns that distinguish them from ordinary proverbs and other forms of oral discourse. They are characterised by explicit attribution of speech, personification of non-human entities, formulaic expression, and a high degree of semantic condensation. These features contribute to their memorability, communicative effectiveness, and cultural relevance.

1. Typical Structure of Kusaal Wellerisms

The wellerisms examined in this study display a remarkably consistent structural pattern. In their most common form, they consist of three elements: a speaker, a reporting verb, and a quoted statement. Formally, the structure can be represented as follows:

Speaker + *ye* (‘says’) + Quoted Statement

The speaker is typically an animal, bird, insect, or other non-human creature, while the verb *ye* functions as a quotative marker introducing the utterance. The quoted statement constitutes the proverbial message itself and often contains the wisdom, observation, or moral lesson intended by the expression. Examples from the corpus include:

Akɔndiŋ ye, “Nyɔɔrɛ an gɛlla.”

(The partridge says: life is eggs).

Abaa ye, “Pv’ab ki’isvɔg yɛla ka on ɛnti maal naae ka ke ka dunia dim nyɛ.”

(The dog says: because women are deniers, it ensures that everyone witnesses itsact).

Anwaaŋ ye, “Nyɔ’ɔg mi’igid nyain laala.”

(The monkey says: chest pain is better than death).

The explicit attribution of speech distinguishes wellerisms from ordinary proverbs, which are often presented as anonymous truths or generalized observations. By assigning the utterance to a particular speaker, Kusaal wellerisms create a dramatic and dialogic effect that enhances their rhetorical force. The quoted statement is interpreted not merely as an abstract truth but as a perspective grounded in the experiences of the speaking creature. This structure allows speakers to communicate sensitive messages indirectly through the voice of another entity, thereby reducing the face-threatening potential of criticism, advice, or moral judgement.

The speaker component is particularly important because the choice of animal is rarely arbitrary. Different creatures embody different behavioural traits and cultural associations. Consequently, the identity of the speaker often contributes significantly to the interpretation of the wellerism. A monkey may symbolize intelligence or foresight, a dog may represent persistence or social commentary, while a hyena may evoke ideas of opportunism or survival. The meaning of the wellerism therefore emerges from the interaction between the quoted statement and the cultural symbolism associated with the speaker.

2. Personification and the Prefix A- The Prefix A- as a Marker of Person-hood

One of the most distinctive structural features of Kusaal wellerisms is the systematic use of the prefix A- before the names of animals and other creatures. This feature appears consistently throughout the corpus which serves an important linguistic and cultural function. Examples include:

Animal in Kusaal	Animal in English	Wellerism Form	Personification
Baa	dog	A-baa	A-dog
Nwaaŋ	monkey	A-nwaaŋ	A-monkey
zaŋkua’ar	hyena	A-zaŋkua’ar	A-hyena
Dayuug	rat	A-dayuug	A-rat
Kuug	mouse	A-kuug	A-mouse
zuuŋg	vulture	A-zuuŋg	A-vulture
salinsaa	ant	A-salinsaa	A-ant
sisɔm	grasshopper	A-sisɔm	A-grasshopper
batikantɔŋ	busturd	A-batikantɔŋ	A-busturd

In ordinary discourse, these animals are not necessarily referred to with the prefix. Within wellerisms, however, the addition of “A-” transforms them from ordinary creatures into socially recognizable persons. The prefix functions as a marker of personhood, enabling

animals to participate in human social interaction as speakers, thinkers, advisers, critics, and moral commentators.

The use of “A-” can therefore be understood as a linguistic strategy of personification. Through this process, animals are endowed with human characteristics, including speech, reasoning, emotions, intentions, and moral awareness. Personification is not merely an ornamental feature of the discourse; rather, it constitutes a fundamental mechanism through which the wellerisms generate meaning. By granting animals human agency, the wellerisms create an alternative communicative space in which observations about human behaviour can be expressed indirectly and often humorously.

The personifying function of “A-” performs several interconnected discourse functions. First, it humanises non-human creatures, allowing them to participate in social and moral discourse. Second, it assigns agency and authority to the animal speaker, making its observations appear credible and meaningful. Third, it facilitates indirect criticism by enabling speakers to discuss sensitive issues through animal voices rather than direct personal reference. Fourth, it creates distance between the speaker and the criticism being expressed, thereby reducing the risk of interpersonal conflict. Finally, it allows animals to function as symbolic spokespersons for human experiences and cultural values.

From a cognitive perspective, this personification reflects broader conceptual processes through which human beings understand themselves and their social worlds. The recurring attribution of human qualities to animals suggests the operation of the conceptual metaphor: Animals are people. This metaphor enables listeners to interpret animal experiences in terms of human behaviour, motivations, and social relationships. Closely related to this is another conceptual mapping: Animal experience is human experience.

Through these mappings, the challenges, desires, fears, and strategies attributed to animals become vehicles for understanding corresponding aspects of human life. The personified animal thus serves as a culturally meaningful intermediary between the natural world and the social world. Consequently, Kusaal wellerisms construct a symbolic universe in which animals are not merely creatures of the environment but active participants in society. They become moral agents whose voices articulate collective wisdom, social criticism, and cultural philosophies accumulated through generations of communal experience.

Formulaic Features of Kusaal Wellerisms

In addition to their distinctive personification strategies, Kusaal wellerisms exhibit several formulaic characteristics that contribute to their effectiveness as oral expressions. These include brevity, dialogic presentation, narrative compression, humour, and irony. One notable feature is brevity. Like proverbs generally, wellerisms are characteristically short and economical in form. Complex social observations and moral lessons are compressed into concise statements that can be easily remembered and transmitted across generations. Despite their brevity, however, they often communicate multiple layers of meaning that become apparent only within appropriate contexts.

A second characteristic is their dialogic structure. The presence of an explicitly identified speaker creates the impression of direct speech and transforms the proverb into

a miniature dramatic performance. This dialogic quality enhances audience engagement and contributes to the vividness of the expression. Rather than merely stating a truth, the wellerism allows listeners to imagine the speaking animal articulating its perspective on life.

A third feature is narrative compression. Although most wellerisms consist of only a single sentence, they frequently imply larger narratives and experiences. For example, the statement that “the mouse examines the pot before jumping into it” evokes a broader story of caution, risk assessment, and survival. Similarly, the dog’s complaint about women’s denial presupposes a wider social narrative concerning recognition, evidence, and trust. Through such compression, extensive cultural knowledge is condensed into highly economical forms.

Humour also constitutes an important feature of Kusaal wellerisms. The attribution of distinctly human concerns to animals often creates amusing and memorable images. The humour is not merely for entertainment; rather, it serves as a pedagogical tool that makes moral lessons more acceptable and easier to remember. By laughing at the animal speaker, listeners simultaneously reflect on analogous human behaviours.

Closely related to humour is irony. Many wellerisms derive their communicative force from contrasts between appearance and reality, expectation and outcome, or intention and consequence. Such ironic juxtapositions encourage reflection and invite listeners to infer meanings that extend beyond the literal content of the statement. Irony therefore functions as an important mechanism through which wellerisms communicate social criticism and cultural wisdom indirectly.

Taken together, these structural characteristics, formulaic speech attribution, personification through the prefix “A-”, brevity, dialogue, narrative compression, humour, and irony, distinguish Kusaal wellerisms from other forms of proverbial discourse. They provide the formal foundation upon which the contextual, pragmatic, and metaphorical meanings discussed in subsequent sections are constructed.

Thematic Presentation of Data Survival and Resilience

Data 1. The Partridge

Akɔndiŋ ye, “Nyɔɔrɛ an gɛlla.”

Literal meaning: ‘The partridge says: life is eggs.’

Context of Use: This wellerism is typically employed to encourage individuals who are experiencing hardship, failure, illness, poverty, or disappointment. It may be used to console someone who has lost property, failed in an enterprise, or encountered misfortune. Elders often invoke it to remind younger people not to lose hope in difficult circumstances.

Interpretation and Analysis: The proverb emphasizes the primacy of life over material possessions and temporary setbacks. The partridge associates life with eggs because eggs symbolize reproduction, continuity, and future possibilities. Just as a living partridge can lay more eggs even after losing previous ones, a living person can recover from loss and rebuild their life. The wellerism therefore promotes optimism, resilience, and perseverance. The underlying lesson is that survival itself constitutes a valuable resource from which future success can emerge. The expression reflects the Kusaa worldview that no loss is permanent as long as life remains.

Data 2. The Donkey

Abɔŋ ye, “Onbidne yoog, yoog n paadi o puann tiim.”

Literal meaning: ‘The donkey says: it eats indiscriminately because somewhere among what it eats is medicine for its stomach.’

Context of Use: This wellerism is used when discussing experimentation, persistence, or exploratory efforts. It may be directed at individuals trying different approaches to solve a problem or achieve a goal. It is also used to justify broad attempts at finding solutions where certainty is lacking.

Interpretation and Analysis: The donkey's indiscriminate feeding behaviour is presented as a survival strategy. Although not every plant it consumes is beneficial, one among them may provide the remedy it seeks. The wellerism therefore encourages persistence and adaptability rather than passivity. The saying reflects the recognition that success is often achieved through repeated attempts rather than through perfect knowledge. It teaches that individuals should continue searching for opportunities because solutions frequently emerge from unexpected sources.

Data 3. The Monkey

Anwaan ye, “Nyɔ'ɔg mi'igid nyain laala.”

Literal meaning: ‘The monkey says: chest pain is better than death.’

Context of Use: The expression is commonly used to comfort individuals enduring suffering, sickness, financial difficulties, or other forms of adversity. It may also be employed when encouraging patience during difficult circumstances.

Interpretation and Analysis: The monkey contrasts two undesirable conditions—pain and death and concludes that pain is preferable because it allows continued existence. The saying communicates a philosophy of endurance whereby temporary suffering is accepted as part of life. The wellerism encourages individuals to tolerate hardship rather than succumb to despair. It reflects a pragmatic understanding of human existence in which resilience is valued above comfort.

Data 4. The Vulture

Azɔvɔŋ ye, “ɔn mɔri o yalimis bɔɔdi o yuud.”

Literal meaning: ‘The vulture says: it uses its unpleasant character to attain old age.’

Context of Use: This wellerism is used when discussing unconventional survival strategies or when explaining why certain people behave in ways that society considers undesirable. It may also be used to defend behaviour motivated by self-preservation.

Interpretation and Analysis: The vulture survives by feeding on carrion, a behaviour many animals avoid. Yet this very behaviour enables it to live and thrive. The wellerism suggests that survival sometimes requires actions that may not be socially admired but are nonetheless effective. The saying does not necessarily celebrate negative behaviour; rather, it acknowledges that adaptation to reality is often essential for survival.

Prudence and Foresight

Data 5. The Monkey

Anwaan ye, “On nini lalnɛ, alazug, yɛla ya’a kenna, on ɛɛnti deŋin kaasnɛ, nidib ti ye ba kaas la, ka on mɛ nintɔ’ɔm paɛ na”

Literal meaning: ‘The monkey says: its eyes are deep, therefore it begins crying before everyone else whenever trouble is approaching.’

Context of Use: This wellerism is employed when referring to people who foresee danger before others do. It is often used to praise wisdom, foresight, and preparedness.

Interpretation and Analysis: The monkey's deep eyes symbolize heightened perception and awareness. Its ability to cry before trouble arrives reflects advance recognition of danger. The wellerism therefore values vigilance and preparation. The lesson is that wise individuals anticipate problems before they become crises.

Data 6. The Savannah Monitor Lizard

Agbanzavɔ ye, “Nif kane nyɛla ɔn mɔri o yɛla.”

Literal meaning: ‘The monitor lizard says: the eye that sees should have its own trouble.’

Context of Use: This saying is used to caution people who involve themselves in matters they know about or witness. It often arises when discussing responsibility, accountability, or the consequences of knowledge.

Interpretation and Analysis: The proverb suggests that knowledge brings obligations and risks. Once a person becomes aware of a situation, neutrality becomes difficult. The expression recognizes that awareness often carries responsibility.

Data 7. The Hyena

Azaŋkua'ar ye, "On kan'ar win nɛ o kpɛn'ɛb yɛla ka di ya'a kpɛlim yiib na, o na nɔki o paŋ yina"

Literal meaning: 'The hyena says: it prays and plans before entering; as for coming out, it will use its strength.'

Context of Use: This wellerism is frequently cited before embarking on difficult ventures such as business, migration, litigation, or leadership responsibilities.

Interpretation and Analysis: The saying stresses careful planning before action while recognizing the need for determination once action has begun. Success requires both preparation and courage.

Data 8. The Mouse

Akuug ye, "Ba ɛnti ti'ebnɛ sia gɔs ka nyaan sigid siŋin."

Literal meaning: 'The mouse says: we inspect the pot before jumping into it.'

Context of Use: The expression is used to advise caution before making important decisions, entering relationships, accepting offers, or undertaking risky ventures.

Interpretation and Analysis: The mouse's behaviour reflects calculated caution. The wellerism teaches that prudent people assess situations before committing themselves.

Self-Reliance and Responsibility

Data 9. The Dog

Abaa ye, "On ye o maali dunia, ka duniadim zan'as; ka o kenna ye maali o teŋ, ka o teŋdim zan'as; ka o kɔŋ ka ye o maali o yir, o yidim zan'as; ka on yu'um kɔŋ ka nɔk maali o digisir."

Literal Meaning: 'The dog says: it wanted to improve the world, but the world refused; it came to improve its town, but the townspeople refused; it came to improve its household, but the household refused; therefore, it decided to improve itself.'

Context of Use: This wellerism is commonly used when advising people who expend excessive effort attempting to change others while neglecting their own personal development. Elders may invoke it when discussing leadership, social reform, family disputes, or personal growth.

Interpretation and Analysis: The dog's progressive retreat from the world to the self reflects a realization that personal transformation is often more achievable than transforming society. The saying encourages self-improvement as the foundation of broader social change. Rather than becoming frustrated by the resistance of others, individuals are urged to focus on what lies within their control.

Data 10. The Rat

Adayuug ye, “Dikanε bε on pɔɔrin la ma’a an ɔn din, ka dini bε o nɔɔrin la nan ka’ o din.”

Literal Meaning: ‘The rat says: the food in its stomach belongs to it, but the food in its mouth does not yet belong to it.’

Context of Use: The expression is often used in discussions of business, farming, inheritance, examinations, and other situations where success is anticipated but not yet secured.

Interpretation and Analysis: The rat distinguishes between what has already been acquired and what is merely expected. The wellerism cautions against premature celebration and overconfidence. It reminds individuals that possession is only certain when an objective has been fully attained.

Sexuality and Gender Relations

Data 11. The Dog

Abaa ye, “Pɔ’ab ki’isug yɛla ka on εanti maal naae ka ke ka dunia wɔsa nyɛt la.”

Literal Meaning: ‘The dog says: because women are deniers, whenever it finishes mating it ensures that the whole world witnesses it.’

Context of Use: This wellerism is used when discussing evidence, accountability, trust, and the need to substantiate one's claims. It often arises in situations where individuals are accused of denying obvious facts.

Interpretation and Analysis: The dog's behaviour is portrayed as a response to anticipated denial. The saying humorously suggests that evidence is necessary because people may later reject or distort the truth. The lesson extends beyond gender relations to broader issues of proof and accountability.

Data 12. The Ant

Asalinsaa ye, “On bɔn pɔ zu’oe amaa o nɔkid pa’ali o sida.”

Literal Meaning: ‘The ant says: its genital organ is not large, yet it continually displays it to its husband.’

Context of Use: This wellerism is often employed to criticize boastfulness, self-advertisement, or unnecessary display of one's possessions or abilities.

Interpretation and Analysis: The ant's exaggerated display of something insignificant satirizes human tendencies toward vanity and self-promotion. The expression teaches modesty and warns against drawing attention to trivial achievements.

Data 13. The Hedgehog

Ayvgvdir ye, “Yv’vη pən anε di’igir dinε ke ka ɔn ken ka ziidi o yu’or.”

Literal Meaning: ‘The hedgehog says: a woman's genitalia at night is a surprise; therefore, it always moves with its penis ready.’

Context of Use: The wellerism is often cited humorously in discussions of preparedness, readiness, and taking advantage of opportunities.

Interpretation and Analysis: Although couched in sexual imagery, the broader message concerns preparedness. Opportunities often arise unexpectedly, and individuals who remain prepared are better positioned to benefit from them.

Endurance and Achievement

Data 14. The Lizard

Abangia ye, “Ba εenti su’anε kazug mu’e.”

Literal Meaning: ‘The lizard says: people hide in order to obtain a red head.’

Context of Use: The expression is used to encourage patience, sacrifice, and commitment in the pursuit of success.

Interpretation and Analysis: The red head symbolizes distinction, honour, or achievement. The wellerism teaches that worthwhile accomplishments often require hardship, discipline, and periods of isolation.

Data 15. The Hyena

Azaŋkua’ar ye, “Beŋa tigr benε koligin.”

Literal Meaning: ‘The hyena says: one can only be satisfied with beans at the waterhole.’

Context of Use: This saying is often used when discussing favourable conditions for success or the importance of timing and circumstance.

Interpretation and Analysis: The wellerism suggests that achievement depends not only on effort but also on context. Even valuable resources become meaningful only when the conditions are right.

Data 16. The Grasshopper

Asisəm ye, “Mɔɔd ya’a nam pɔ nyuo’e naae, zusvη pɔ’vsvg nan ka’.”

Literal Meaning: ‘The grasshopper says: if the bush has not finished burning, congratulations are premature.’

Context of Use: This expression is frequently used in situations where people celebrate before completing a task or overcoming a challenge.

Interpretation and Analysis: The wellerism warns against premature triumphalism. It teaches that success should only be acknowledged when the process has been fully completed.

Honesty and Human Weaknesses

Data 17. The Bustard

Abatikantɔŋ ye, “Ba zan’a pɔ gbɛɛr tɛŋ ka zun’e gbeend tɛŋ.”

Literal Meaning: ‘The bustard says: we claim we do not sleep on the ground, yet we eventually sleep on the ground.’

Context of Use: The saying is employed to criticize hypocrisy, inconsistency, and failure to practice what one preaches.

Interpretation and Analysis: The contrast between claim and reality exposes human tendencies toward self-deception and dishonesty. The wellerism reminds individuals that actions ultimately reveal true character.

Data 18. The Toad

Mgbam/Pɔnnir ye, “Tɔ’vɔd pɔ tɔ’v ka yampɔvɔn lubidaa.”

Literal Meaning: ‘There is no insult without throwing someone behind the house.’

Context of Use: This expression is used when discussing the consequences of disrespectful behaviour, conflict, or verbal abuse.

Interpretation and Analysis: The saying highlights the causal relationship between offensive actions and social repercussions. It teaches accountability and encourages restraint in speech.

Social Relations and Community Life

Data 19. The Monkey

Anwaan ye, “Li ɛnti malis nɛ ka ba zɔt ka gɔrigid biis.”

Literal Meaning: ‘The monkey says: it is only when conditions are favourable that they run while carrying babies.’

Context of Use: This wellerism is used when discussing collective responsibilities, family welfare, and the importance of supportive environments.

Interpretation and Analysis: The monkey recognizes that caring for dependants requires favourable circumstances. The saying highlights the relationship between social support and collective well-being.

Data 20. The Cattle Egret

Nikimpɛɛlin ye, “Ba ɛɛnti kɔ’ɔŋɛ yidim ka dɔl yadim.”

Literal Meaning: ‘The cattle egret says: we follow townspeople when our own people are absent.’

Context of Use: This wellerism is commonly used in discussions of migration, social support networks, friendship, and communal solidarity.

Interpretation and Analysis: The cattle egret acknowledges the necessity of seeking assistance beyond one's immediate kinship group when circumstances require it. The saying emphasizes adaptability, cooperation, and the importance of maintaining positive social relationships.

In all, these wellerisms reveal a rich moral and philosophical system centred on self-improvement, preparedness, perseverance, accountability, moderation, social responsibility, and communal interdependence. Although expressed through the voices of personified animals, they ultimately articulate human experiences and cultural values that are central to Kusaa society.

Context and Functions of Kusaa Wellerisms

A defining feature of Kusaa wellerisms is that their meanings are inseparable from the contexts in which they are used. Like proverbs generally, they derive their communicative force not from their literal wording alone but from the social situations, cultural knowledge, and communicative intentions surrounding their use. When considered in isolation, many wellerisms appear humorous, simple, or even obscure. However, within actual interactions they become powerful tools for conveying criticism, advice, warnings, conflict mediation, and moral guidance. This supports the view in linguistic anthropology and proverb studies that verbal art acquires meaning through performance and social use rather than through text alone (Hymes, 1974; Bauman, 1986; Duranti, 1997; Yankah, 1989).

The Kusaa data show that context is essential for interpretation. For instance, the partridge's statement “Life is eggs” does not reveal its intended meaning literally. Yet when used to comfort someone facing loss, illness, miscarriage or disappointment, it communicates hope and resilience, emphasising that as long as life continues, opportunities for recovery remain. Similarly, the mouse's claim that it examines the waist before jumping into a pot is understood not as a comment on animal behaviour but as advice to act cautiously before making important decisions. Meaning therefore emerges through the interaction of speaker, audience, and circumstance rather than from the words themselves.

Within everyday discourse, wellerisms frequently function as indirect criticism. Instead of confronting people openly, speakers employ personified animals to comment on undesirable behaviour. The bustard that claims it never sleeps on the ground only to end up doing so criticises hypocrisy and inconsistency, while the ant that constantly displays something insignificant mocks boastfulness and self-importance. By placing criticism in the mouths of animals, speakers can express disapproval without creating unnecessary hostility. This indirectness reflects broader politeness strategies that help preserve social harmony while still communicating corrective messages (Brown & Levinson, 1987; Leech, 1983).

Closely related to criticism is the use of wellerisms for advice and warning. Through memorable animal narratives, speakers encourage prudence, foresight, perseverance, and responsible conduct. The mouse's careful inspection of the pot advises caution before undertaking any venture; the monkey that cries before trouble arrives encourages preparedness; and the grasshopper that warns against congratulating someone before the bush has finished burning cautions against premature celebration. Such expressions serve as repositories of communal wisdom, transmitting lessons that guide behaviour across generations (Finnegan, 2012; Mieder, 2004).

Kusaal wellerisms also play an important role in conflict management and dispute resolution. In situations where direct confrontation may threaten relationships, speakers invoke wellerisms to shift attention from personal accusations to broader moral principles. For example, the dog's insistence that witnesses should observe its actions may be cited in disputes concerning accountability or truthfulness. By framing disagreement through proverbial wisdom rather than direct attack, participants are encouraged to reflect on the underlying issue without becoming defensive. In this way, wellerisms function as culturally recognised mediatory devices that promote reconciliation and social cohesion.

Beyond resolving immediate conflicts, wellerisms contribute to the broader regulation of social behaviour. Through repeated use, they reinforce communal norms and values while discouraging actions considered undesirable. Many promote virtues such as patience, honesty, diligence, self-reliance, responsibility, and perseverance. The rat's distinction between actual possession and anticipated gain warns against complacency, while the dog's decision to improve itself rather than reform the entire world emphasises personal responsibility. Others condemn hypocrisy, carelessness, dishonesty, and excessive pride. Consequently, wellerisms operate as informal mechanisms of moral instruction and social control, helping to sustain the ethical foundations of the community.

A particularly significant aspect of Kusaal wellerisms is their face-saving function. Social interactions often require advice, correction, or criticism, but direct expression of such messages can threaten an individual's dignity and public image. By communicating through animal characters, wellerisms soften potentially face-threatening acts. A boastful person may be reminded of the ant that proudly displays something insignificant, while a reckless individual may be indirectly compared to a mouse that failed to inspect the pot before jumping into it. The intended lesson is communicated effectively, yet the recipient is allowed to preserve dignity and avoid public embarrassment. This indirectness explains much of the continuing relevance of wellerisms in Kusaal society.

Overall, the analysis demonstrates that Kusaal wellerisms are far more than entertaining forms of verbal art. Their meanings emerge through context, and their social functions extend to criticism, advice, warning, conflict resolution, face management, and the reinforcement of communal values. They serve as culturally sanctioned instruments through which wisdom is transmitted, behaviour is regulated, and interpersonal relationships are negotiated. Their enduring significance lies not merely in what they say but in what they accomplish within the social life of the community.

Metaphorical Conceptualisation in Kusaal Wellerisms

One of the most remarkable features of Kusaal wellerisms is their reliance on metaphorical reasoning. Although the expressions appear to describe the experiences and behaviours of animals, birds, insects, and other creatures, their ultimate concern is human life and social behaviour. The wellerisms therefore operate through conceptual mappings in which concrete experiences associated with animals are used to understand abstract human realities.

This observation supports the central claim of Conceptual Metaphor Theory (Lakoff & Johnson, 1980; Kövecses, 2010) that metaphor is not merely a literary ornament but a fundamental cognitive mechanism through which people conceptualise experience. In Kusaal wellerisms, animal behaviour constitutes the primary source domain from which speakers derive insights about survival, success, responsibility, social relationships, morality, and human conduct.

Animal Behaviour as a Source Domain

A striking characteristic of the corpus is that nearly all the wellerisms derive their imagery from the observable behaviour of animals. For instance, the partridge lays eggs, the monkey anticipates danger, the mouse inspects the pot before entering, the vulture survives through scavenging, and the rat distinguishes between food already eaten and food not yet secured. These behaviours are projected onto human experiences through metaphorical mappings.

The process reflects a broader conceptual pattern whereby animal experience serves as the source domain and human experience serves as the target domain. Rather than speaking directly about people, Kusaal speakers employ animals as symbolic representations of human conduct. Through this strategy, complex social realities become easier to conceptualise, communicate, and remember. The cognitive effectiveness of these mappings stems from their grounding in everyday observation. Since speakers are familiar with the habits and characteristics of the animals involved, the lessons conveyed by the wellerisms become immediately accessible and culturally meaningful.

Major Conceptual Metaphors

Life is a Resource

Relevant Data: Data 1 (Partridge), Data 2 (Donkey), Data 3 (Monkey), Data 4 (Vulture). The first major conceptual metaphor emerging from the corpus is:

LIFE IS A RESOURCE

This metaphor conceptualises life as a valuable asset that enables future opportunities, recovery, and survival.

Data 1, the partridge's statement "*Life is eggs*," presents life as the source from which future possibilities emerge. Just as eggs represent reproduction and continuity, life itself becomes the foundation upon which future achievements depend.

Data 2, involving the donkey's indiscriminate feeding, similarly emphasises survival through persistent searching for solutions. The possibility of discovering medicine among ordinary food symbolises the opportunities embedded within continued existence.

Data 3 ("*Chest pain is better than death*") explicitly contrasts suffering with extinction. Survival is valued above comfort because only the living possess the capacity to overcome hardship.

Data 4 portrays the vulture surviving through behaviours that may be socially undesirable but nevertheless sustain life. The central message is that adaptation promotes survival. Collectively, these wellerisms reflect a cultural model in which survival is the prerequisite for all other forms of success.

Knowing is Seeing

Relevant Data: Data 5 (Monkey), Data 6 (Savannah Monitor Lizard). Another recurring conceptual metaphor is:

KNOWING IS SEEING

This metaphor, widely attested cross-linguistically (Lakoff & Johnson, 1980), conceptualises knowledge and understanding in terms of visual perception.

In Data 5, the monkey's deep eyes enable it to recognise approaching danger before others do. Visual depth becomes a metaphor for insight and foresight. Similarly, Data 6 states: "*The eye that sees should have its own matter*." The wellerism establishes a direct relationship between perception and responsibility. To see is to know, and to know is to become implicated in what is known. The metaphor therefore links awareness with wisdom, responsibility, and social obligation.

Success is a Journey

Relevant Data: Data 9 (Dog), Data 17 (Grasshopper). A third metaphor emerging from the corpus is:

SUCCESS IS A JOURNEY

This conceptualisation reflects a common metaphor identified by Lakoff and Johnson (1980), whereby life goals are understood as destinations reached through movement.

In Data 9, the dog moves progressively from attempting to improve the world, to the town, to the household, and finally itself. The movement through successive domains mirrors a journey toward wisdom and self-discovery.

Data 17, the grasshopper's observation that congratulations should not be offered until the bush has finished burning, similarly portrays achievement as a process rather than an event. The destination has not been reached until the task is fully completed. The metaphor emphasises perseverance, progress, and the gradual nature of accomplishment.

Responsibility is a Burden

Relevant Data: Data 6 (Savannah Monitor Lizard), Data 20 (Monkey). A further conceptual metaphor identifiable in the corpus is:

RESPONSIBILITY IS A BURDEN

This metaphor conceptualises obligations as weights that individuals must carry.

Data 6 links knowledge with responsibility. The eye that sees acquires obligations and therefore bears a burden unavailable to those who remain ignorant.

Data 20, where the monkey runs while carrying its young, similarly presents responsibility as something physically carried. The burden of caring for dependants becomes a metaphor for social obligations more generally.

The metaphor reflects a cultural understanding that duties require effort, sacrifice, and endurance.

Opportunity is Food

Relevant Data: Data 2 (Donkey), Data 16 (Hyena), Data 10 (Rat). One of the most productive metaphors in the corpus is:

OPPORTUNITY IS FOOD

Food represents something desirable, beneficial, and necessary for survival. Consequently, opportunities are conceptualised as edible resources that must be sought, secured, and consumed. The donkey's search for medicinal food symbolises the search for opportunities. The hyena's satisfaction with beans at the waterhole presents achievement as dependent upon access to resources. The rat's distinction between food in its stomach and food still in its mouth differentiates realised opportunities from anticipated ones. Across these examples, food serves as a concrete source domain through which abstract ideas of opportunity, success, and achievement are understood.

Social Relationships are Kinship

Relevant Data: Data 21 (Cattle Egret). The final major metaphor identified in the corpus is:

SOCIAL RELATIONSHIPS ARE KINSHIP

In Data 21, the cattle egret explains that it follows townspeople because its own people are absent. The wellerism extends kinship relations beyond biological relatives to encompass broader social networks. The metaphor reflects a communal worldview in which social support is conceptualised through familial relationships. Individuals survive not merely through personal effort but through connections with others.

Personification as Metaphorical Mapping

Beyond individual conceptual metaphors, the entire corpus is structured around a larger metaphorical framework:

ANIMALS ARE HUMAN ACTORS

This metaphor is facilitated linguistically through the personifying prefix “A-”, which precedes the names of animals in the wellerisms as discussed in 4.2.1. The prefix transforms animals into social persons capable of speaking, reasoning, advising, criticising, and judging. Through this process, animal experiences become symbolic representations of human experiences. The mapping may be represented as follows:

Source Domain	Target Domain
Animal speech	Human communication
Animal behaviour	Human behaviour
Animal survival	Human survival
Animal experience	Human experience
Animal relationships	Human relationship

Personification therefore constitutes the central cognitive mechanism through which the wellerisms operate in Kusaal.

Cultural Models Embedded in Kusaal Wellerisms

The metaphorical patterns identified in the table above reveal broader cultural models that organise Kusaas understanding of human life.

Survival as a Fundamental Value

Data 1–4 consistently portray survival as the foundation of all achievement. Remaining alive is regarded as more important than avoiding hardship.

Self-Improvement Before Social Reform

Data 9 suggests that meaningful change begins with the individual. Personal transformation precedes societal transformation.

Patience and Perseverance

Data 15, 16, and 17 emphasise endurance, delayed gratification, and sustained effort as prerequisites for success.

Communal Living and Interdependence

Data 20 and 21 highlight the importance of social support, cooperation, and collective responsibility.

Moral Accountability

Data 6, 18, and 19 reinforce the principle that actions carry consequences and that individuals must accept responsibility for their behaviour. Taken together, these cultural models demonstrate that Kusaal wellerisms are not merely entertaining verbal performances. Rather, they constitute sophisticated systems of metaphorical thought through which the Kusaasi conceptualise survival, responsibility, success, morality, and social life. By mapping animal experience onto human experience, the wellerisms transform everyday observations into enduring forms of cultural wisdom.

Discussion of Findings

The findings of this paper demonstrate that Kusaal wellerisms are much more than entertaining expressions within oral tradition. They are powerful cultural resources through which the Kusaas interpret human experience, transmit communal wisdom, and regulate social behaviour. Their communicative strength lies in the interaction between context, metaphor, and personification, making them important sites for understanding the relationship between language, culture, and cognition.

A key finding is the centrality of context in the interpretation of wellerisms. Consistent with Yankah's (1989) theory of proverb praxis, the meanings of these expressions cannot be understood solely from their literal wording. Rather, they acquire significance through the situations in which they are used and the shared cultural knowledge of speakers and listeners. Expressions such as *Akɔndiŋ yee*, "*Nyɔɔrɛ an gella*" ('The partridge says: life is eggs') or *Akuug yee*, "*Ba ɛɛnti ti'ebnɛ sia gɔs ka nyaan sigid siŋin*" ('The mouse says: we inspect the pot before jumping into it') communicate lessons about resilience and caution only when interpreted within appropriate social contexts. The findings therefore reinforce the view that context is not an optional element of proverb interpretation but an essential condition for meaning.

The study also provides strong support for Conceptual Metaphor Theory (Lakoff & Johnson, 1980). The wellerisms reveal that abstract aspects of life are understood through more concrete experiences drawn from everyday interaction with animals and the environment. Recurring metaphors such as life is a resource, knowing is seeing, success is a journey, responsibility is a burden, and opportunity is food show how the Kusaasi conceptualise survival, achievement, knowledge, and social obligations through familiar experiences. These metaphorical patterns confirm that metaphor is not merely a stylistic ornament but a fundamental cognitive tool for organising and communicating human experience.

At the same time, the findings support Kövecses' (2010) argument that while some conceptual metaphors may be widespread across cultures, their expression is shaped by local cultural realities. The Kusaal wellerisms draw heavily on animals and creatures that are familiar within the ecological and cultural environment of the Kusaasi. The partridge, monkey, hyena, donkey, mouse, vulture, and other creatures serve as culturally meaningful source domains through which human behaviour is interpreted and evaluated. This demonstrates how universal cognitive processes interact with culture-specific experiences to produce distinctive forms of metaphorical thought.

The paper further aligns with broader African proverb scholarship, which has long recognised proverbs as repositories of communal wisdom and instruments of social regulation (Finnegan, 2012; Mieder, 2004; Yankah, 1989). The Kusaal wellerisms examined here perform a range of social functions, including advising, warning, criticising, resolving conflicts, and promoting social harmony. Their indirect nature enables speakers to address sensitive issues without causing unnecessary confrontation, thereby preserving interpersonal relationships and community cohesion. In this way, the wellerisms function not only as literary expressions but also as practical tools for social interaction.

Another notable finding is the role of personification in the construction of meaning. Through the personifying prefix *A-*, animals are transformed into speaking social actors capable of reasoning, judging, and commenting on human affairs. This strategy allows speakers to project human experiences onto animal characters and, in turn, use those characters as mirrors through which society can reflect on itself. The result is a highly effective form of indirect communication that combines humour, creativity, and moral instruction.

More broadly, the paper contributes to the growing field of cognitive paremiology by demonstrating the value of African-language data for understanding the cognitive foundations of proverbial discourse. Much of the existing literature has focused on European and Asian traditions, leaving African proverb systems comparatively underrepresented. By analysing metaphorical mappings, personification strategies, and cultural models in Kusaal wellerisms, this paper expands the empirical scope of cognitive proverb research and highlights the relevance of African oral traditions to contemporary linguistic theory.

Overall, the Kusaal wellerisms analysed in this paper reveal a rich interplay between language, culture, cognition, and social practice. They show that proverbial discourse is not merely a collection of inherited sayings but a dynamic system of cultural knowledge through which communities make sense of human experience, negotiate social relationships, and transmit collective wisdom from one generation to the next. Their continued use underscores the enduring importance of oral traditions as both cultural heritage and living forms of social communication.

Conclusion

This paper has examined twenty Kusaal wellerisms with the aim of exploring their contextual meanings, metaphorical structures, personification strategies, and cultural significance. The analysis has shown that Kusaal wellerisms constitute a distinctive genre of oral literature through which the Kusaasi encode communal wisdom, social values, and culturally grounded understandings of human experience. Far from being merely humorous sayings attributed to animals, these expressions function as sophisticated communicative resources that facilitate social commentary, moral instruction, conflict management, and the transmission of indigenous knowledge. A central finding of the paper is that the interpretation of Kusaal wellerisms is inseparable from context. Their meanings do not reside solely in the literal content of the utterances but emerge through their deployment in specific communicative situations. Whether used to advise, warn, criticise, persuade, reconcile disputants, or regulate behaviour, the wellerisms derive

their effectiveness from their ability to communicate sensitive messages indirectly while preserving social relationships. In this respect, the findings provide further support for Yankah's (1989) view that proverbial meaning is fundamentally shaped by context and performance.

The paper has also demonstrated that personification is a defining feature of Kusaal wellerisms. Through the attachment of the prefix A- to animal names, non-human creatures are transformed into speaking social actors capable of reasoning, judging, advising, and commenting on human affairs. This linguistic strategy enables speakers to discuss human experiences through animal voices, thereby creating a symbolic space in which criticism, wisdom, and social observations can be expressed in culturally acceptable ways. The findings suggest that personification in Kusaal wellerisms is not merely a stylistic device but an important cognitive and discourse strategy that facilitates indirect communication and moral reflection.

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